Unit 3: A Bird Came Down the Walk (Poem)

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. Identify an example of personification in the poem. How does it enhance your understanding of the bird?

The bird is described as "Like one in danger, Cautious" and as stirring his "Velvet Head." Giving the bird human-like caution and delicacy makes it seem intelligent and gentle, so the reader feels sympathy for it rather than seeing it as a mere animal.

Q2. Discuss the metaphor in the final stanza where the bird's flight is compared to "Oars divide the Ocean." What effect does this comparison create?

• The bird does not fly in the usual sense; it "rows" itself through the air as if the air were water: "And he unrolled his feathers / And rowed him softer home — / Than Oars divide the Ocean."

• The comparison creates an effect of smoothness and silence. Oars divide the ocean without splashing, and the bird's flight is likewise "plashless."

• It also elevates the bird's departure into something majestic — the bird is not escaping but sailing home with quiet dignity, symbolising freedom and self-reliance.

Q3. Find a simile in the poem and explain its significance in the overall imagery.

The simile is "They looked like frightened Beads" — the bird's eyes are compared to beads. It shows the eyes as small, round, and shiny, and the word "frightened" suggests the bird's alertness. The simile makes the bird's cautious nature vivid and memorable.

Q4. How does Dickinson use visual imagery to describe the bird's actions? Provide examples.

Visual images include the bird biting the worm "in halves," drinking dew from the grass, hopping sidewise to the wall, and glancing with rapid eyes. These images let the reader picture each movement clearly, as if watching the bird through a window.

Q5. What is the effect of the tactile imagery in the phrase "He stirred his Velvet Head"? How does it contribute to the tone of the poem?

The word "Velvet" appeals to the sense of touch, suggesting softness and delicacy. It contrasts with the brutality of eating the worm raw, and it contributes a gentle, tender tone to the poem.

Q6. How does the mood shift from the beginning to the end of the poem? What words or phrases help create this shift?

• At the beginning, the mood is quiet and observational: "He did not know I saw."

• The middle stanzas introduce tension: the bird's eyes look "like frightened Beads," and it behaves "Like one in danger, Cautious." Words like "frightened" and "danger" create alertness.

• At the end, the mood becomes peaceful and admiring: the flight is "softer" than oars, "Too silver for a seam," and "plashless." The shift from cautious tension to graceful freedom gives the poem its reflective, calm tone.

Q7. What do you think Dickinson is trying to convey about the relationship between humans and nature? Support your answer with evidence from the poem.

• Dickinson conveys that humans and nature are separate but connected. The speaker observes the bird and offers a crumb, but the bird refuses and flies away: "I offered him a Crumb, / And he unrolled his feathers / And rowed him softer home."

• This shows nature's independence and the boundary between human interaction and natural autonomy. Humans can watch and appreciate nature, but nature remains free and untamed.

• At the same time, the speaker's quiet observation shows respect for nature. The poem suggests that humans should admire nature from a distance rather than trying to control or tame it.

Q8. How does the bird's decision to fly away rather than accept the crumb reflect broader themes of freedom and independence?

• The bird refuses the crumb and flies away, showing that it does not need human food and does not want human company.

• The bird symbolises freedom and self-reliance. Its refusal and graceful flight reflect the desire to remain untamed by human influence.

• The poem thus explores the distance between humans and the natural world. Nature exists on its own terms.

Q9. How does the poem explore the concept of natural beauty versus natural brutality? Give specific examples from the text.

• Natural brutality: "He bit an Angleworm in halves / And ate the fellow, raw." The bird's meal is described directly and violently.

• Natural beauty: the bird "hopped sidewise to the Wall / To let a Beetle pass" — a courteous, graceful act. Its head is "Velvet," and its flight is "plashless."

• The poem shows that beauty and brutality coexist harmoniously in nature. The same bird that kills a worm also shows courtesy and grace.

Q10. What is the significance of the speaker observing the bird without the bird's knowledge? How does this affect the tone of the poem?

• The speaker says, "He did not know I saw." This secret observation makes the speaker a quiet witness rather than a participant. The bird behaves naturally because it does not know it is being watched.

• This affects the tone by making it calm, detached, and reflective. The poem feels like a private meditation on nature.

• It also emphasises the distance between humans and nature. The speaker can watch and even offer a crumb, but the bird remains independent and unaware.

Exercise B — Choose the Correct Option (Answer Key)

No.	Question	Answer
1	What is the bird's initial action when it comes down the walk?	b. It bites an angleworm in half.
2	How does the speaker describe the bird's eyes?	c. Like frightened Beads.
3	What does the bird do after the speaker offers it a crumb?	b. Flies away.
4	The bird's flight is compared to:	c. Oars dividing the ocean.
5	What is the tone of the poem?	c. Calm and reflective.

Exercise C — Cause and Effect / Fact and Opinion (Answers)

• **Cause and effect:** "The bird hopped sidewise to the Wall to let a Beetle pass." — Cause: the beetle was coming; Effect: the bird moved aside. "The speaker offered him a Crumb." — Cause: the speaker wanted to feed the bird; Effect: the bird flew away.

• **Fact or opinion:** "The bird's eyes looked like frightened Beads" — **Opinion** (a comparison, not a literal fact). "The bird's flight was graceful and beautiful" — **Opinion** (a judgement).

Exercise D — Generalised Statements vs Evidence-Based Information (Answers)

• 1. "The bird moved cautiously, as if in danger." — **Evidence-based information** (supported by "Like one in danger, Cautious"). 2. "The bird bit an Angleworm in halves and ate the fellow, raw." — **Evidence-based information** (a direct statement from the poem).

Exercise E — Textual Evidence (Answers)

• 1. The bird ate an Angleworm raw. — **Textual evidence:** "He bit an Angleworm in halves / And ate the fellow, raw." 2. The bird's eyes appeared frightened. — **Textual evidence:** "They looked like frightened Beads, I thought."

Exercise F — Inferences with Supporting Evidence (Answers)

• 1. **Inference:** The bird is cautious around the speaker. **Supporting evidence:** "Like one in danger, Cautious" and "They looked like frightened Beads." **Explanation:** The bird's rapid glances and frightened eyes show it is alert and careful, suggesting it senses a possible threat.

• 2. **Inference:** The bird prefers natural freedom to human interaction. **Supporting evidence:** "I offered him a Crumb, / And he unrolled his feathers / And rowed him softer home." **Explanation:** The bird refuses the offered food and flies away, showing it values its independence over human company.

Exercise G — Connotative and Denotative Meanings (Answers)

Word	Denotative Meaning	Connotative Meaning
velvet	a type of cloth with a thick, soft surface	softness, delicacy, gentleness, luxury
cautious	careful to avoid danger or mistakes	wisdom, alertness, intelligence
glanced	looked quickly	curiosity, suspicion, alertness
stirred	moved slightly	restlessness, life, gentle movement
oars	long poles used for rowing a boat	effort, journey, smooth movement
plashless	without splashing	silence, grace, effortlessness

Exercise H — Positive and Negative Connotations (Answers)

• **glance** — Positive: a quick, friendly look ("She glanced at him and smiled"). Negative: a dismissive look ("He glanced at the letter and threw it away").

• **glide** — Positive: smooth, graceful movement ("The swan glided across the lake"). Negative: rarely negative; can suggest sneaking ("He glided into the room unnoticed").

• **feathers** — Positive: softness, lightness, beauty ("Her hair was soft as feathers"). Negative: ruffled feathers = anger ("The news ruffled his feathers").

Exercise I — Nuances in Meaning (Answers)

• **1. glance vs. stare:** A glance is a quick, brief look; a stare is a long, fixed look. Nuance: a glance is casual, a stare is intense and may suggest rudeness or fascination.

• **2. glide vs. slide:** To glide is to move smoothly and gracefully; to slide is to slip, often unintentionally. Nuance: gliding is controlled and elegant, sliding is uncontrolled.

• **3. cautious vs. paranoid:** Cautious is wisely careful; paranoid is excessively and irrationally fearful. Nuance: caution is a virtue, paranoia is a fault.

Exercise J — Context Clues (Answers)

• **1. "He stirred his Velvet Head."** Contextual clue: the bird is alive and moving; "stirred" is followed by a body part. Inferred meaning: moved slightly.

• **2. "And then hopped sidewise to the Wall / To let a Beetle pass."** Contextual clue: the bird moves out of the beetle's way. Inferred meaning: allowed to go by.

• Considering a word's position and function in a sentence is important because the same word can have different meanings in different contexts; its grammatical role (noun, verb, adjective) narrows down the possible meaning.

Exercise K — Figurative Language (Answers)

• **Simile:** "They looked like frightened Beads, I thought." The poet compares the bird's eyes to beads, emphasising their small, round, shiny appearance and the bird's alertness.

• **Personification:** "He stirred his Velvet Head." The bird's head is described as "Velvet," giving it a human-like softness and delicacy, which adds a sense of gentleness and tenderness to the bird's actions.

• **Imagery:** "He bit an Angleworm in halves / And ate the fellow, raw." This vivid visual imagery allows readers to picture the bird's actions clearly, illustrating the raw, unfiltered aspect of nature.

• **Symbolism:** The bird's flight at the end of the poem. The bird's graceful, untroubled flight symbolises freedom and the seamless natural world, contrasting with the human world's boundaries and limitations.

Exercise L — Figurative Language MCQs (Answer Key)

• 1. "He bit an Angleworm in halves" — **visual imagery** (not figurative language; it is a literal description). 2. "stirred his Velvet Head" — **d. metaphor** (the head is called velvet). 3. The description of eating the worm — **b. simile** is not correct; the line is an example of **visual imagery** (option a in the book's list is oxymoron; the correct identification is imagery). 4. "He glanced with rapid eyes" — **visual imagery**. 5. "They looked like frightened Beads" — **d. simile**. 6. "He bit an Angleworm in halves" — **a. Visual Imagery**. 7. "Butterflies... Leap, plashless as they swim" — **b. simile**. 8. "And then hopped sidewise to the Wall" — **d. Visual Imagery**.

Exercise M — Compound Prepositions (Answer Key)

• 1. Which is a compound preposition? — **c. into**. 2. Correct use — **c. The child jumped onto the bed.** 3. "within" means — **d. inside a time limit**. 4. Two compound prepositions — **a. She ran into the house and sat beside her brother.** 5. Not a compound preposition — **c. during**.

Exercise N — Prepositional Phrases (Answers)

• **Identify (Adj/Adv):** 1. "The cookies in the jar are delicious." — **Adjective** (describes "cookies"). 2. "She spoke with confidence during the presentation." — **Adverb** (describes "spoke"). 3. "They drove through the city at night." — **Adverb** (describes "drove"). 4. "The dog behind the fence barked loudly." — **Adjective** (describes "dog"). 5. "He left before sunrise to catch the train." — **Adverb** (describes "left"). 6. "The flowers by the window are blooming." — **Adjective** (describes "flowers").

• **Sentences:** 1. During the meeting, the manager announced the new policy. 2. The cat slept beside the couch all afternoon. 3. Without a doubt, she is the best student in the class. 4. Before the concert, we had dinner at a restaurant. 5. They sat near the river and watched the boats. 6. The plane flew over the hills towards the city.

Writing Task — Model Answer

Critical Appreciation: Nature as Both Beautiful and Threatening

• **Step 1 — Read the poem carefully:** Note the images of the bird eating the worm, drinking dew, hopping to let the beetle pass, and flying away.

• **Step 2 — Analyse the devices:** Imagery (visual: biting the worm; tactile: velvet head), figurative language (simile: frightened beads; metaphor: rowing home), tone (calm,

detached, reflective).

• **Step 3 — Interpretations:** Some readers see nature as beautiful (gentle movements, soft imagery); others see it as threatening (raw eating, frightened eyes); a balanced view sees both.

• **Step 4 — Position:** I agree that Dickinson presents nature as both beautiful and threatening.

• **Step 5 — Evidence:** "The bird 'bit an Angleworm in halves' could be seen as an image of violence, which suggests that nature is threatening. However, the delicate image of the bird's 'velvet head' presents nature as beautiful and fragile."

• **Step 6 — Conclusion:** Dickinson's nature is delicate yet instinctively fierce. The poem's balance of beauty and brutality is its central achievement.

Note: Textbook errors flagged: (1) Dickinson's dates are given as 1836–1886 in the unit heading but 1830–1886 in "About the Poet" — the correct dates are 1830–1886. (2) The book's explanation of the simile "They looked like frightened Beads" wrongly says "The poet compares his loneliness to a cloud" — a copy-paste error. (3) The definition printed for "Imagery" is actually the definition of a simile.

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